Prepared 7 November 2026 · every figure is computed from the rotas

# New CEA link proposals — at a glance

All 23 proposals against today's link — the three shortlisted ones marked ★, and the nine where 14 days' leave buys 30 days off, as today, marked so — sorted by December rules met, then avoidable fatigue warnings, then by name; a proposal that breaks a hard limit cannot be run as it stands and comes last. Staffing levels and Sunday cover confirmed verbally (29 September 2026); the 26-line link, 5 cover weeks and a ceiling of 219 contracted days a year set on 1 October 2026.

| PROPOSAL · CODE | DECEMBER RULES MET | AVOIDABLE FATIGUE WARNINGS§ | MOST DAYS IN A ROW§ | FULL WEEKENDS OFF | SHORTEST REST BETWEEN SHIFTS§ | SHIFT TIMES | DAYS A YEAR* | HEAVIEST WEEK, MON–SAT | WEEKS ON ONE SHIFT TIME, ALL EARLIES OR ALL LATES | WEEKS MIXING EARLIES AND LATES | WEEK-TO-WEEK CHANGE OF START | FINISHES 23:00+ A YEAR† |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Today's link** 20 weeks | 4 of 9 | 4<br>up to 5§ | 7<br>up to 9§ | 4 in 20<br>about 10 a year · 7 weeks apart at most | 12h 30m | 18 | 219.0 | 43h 50m | 7 of 16<br>blocks 2 (up to 3) | 7 | 4h 00m | 39 |
| **Balanced V5** MB-26-V5<br>30 days off for 14 days' leave | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 4§ | 5<br>up to 10§ | 6 in 26<br>about 12 a year · 6 weeks apart at most | 13h 50m | 16 (7 new) | 218.6 | 42h 55m | 7 of 21<br>blocks 3 (up to 5) | 3 | 4h 06m | 42 |
| **Balanced V6** MB-26-V6<br>30 days off for 14 days' leave | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 4§ | 5<br>up to 10§ | 6 in 26<br>about 12 a year · 6 weeks apart at most | 14h 20m | 17 (8 new) | 218.6 | 42h 55m | 7 of 21<br>blocks 3 (up to 5) | 3 | 4h 08m | 42 |
| **Balanced V7** MB-26-V7<br>30 days off for 14 days' leave | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 20m | 17 (8 new) | 218.6 | 42h 55m | 13 of 21<br>blocks 3 (up to 5) | 3 | 2h 33m | 42 |
| **Both Ways** BW-26-T3 | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 20m | 15 (5 new) | 218.6 | 41h 20m | 16 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 41m | 42 |
| **Clean Slate** CS-26-N2 | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 35m | 16 (10 new) | 218.6 | 42h 00m | 19 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 21m | 42 |
| **Closing Time** CT-26-T2 | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 35m | 13 (5 new) | 218.6 | 42h 00m | 17 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 10m | 42 |
| **Common Ground** CG-26-T8<br>★ shortlisted<br>30 days off for 14 days' leave | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 35m | 13 (6 new) | 218.6 | 42h 30m | 19 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 12m | 42 |
| **Even Keel** EK-26-H1 | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 35m | 15 (7 new) | 218.6 | 42h 00m | 18 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 12) | 1 | 1h 16m | 44 |
| **Even Step** ES-26-T5<br>★ shortlisted | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 35m | 13 (5 new) | 218.6 | 42h 00m | 18 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 30m | 42 |
| **Fair Share** FS-26-T7 | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 35m | 16 (8 new) | 218.6 | 42h 00m | 18 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 19m | 42 |
| **Fine Tune** FT-26-H1 | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 35m | 15 (7 new) | 218.6 | 42h 00m | 16 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 12) | 1 | 1h 10m | 44 |
| **Grand Tour** GT-26-T7<br>30 days off for 14 days' leave | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 35m | 16 (8 new) | 218.6 | 42h 00m | 16 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 16m | 42 |
| **Home Grown** HG-26-T1 | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 35m | 13 (3 new) | 218.6 | 42h 30m | 16 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 26m | 42 |
| **In Step** IS-26-T4 | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 35m | 15 (6 new) | 218.6 | 41h 05m | 18 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 13m | 42 |
| **Long Break** LB-26-F1 | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 6<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 20m | 15 (6 new) | 218.6 | 42h 00m | 16 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 9) | 0 | 1h 44m | 42 |
| **Middle Ground** MG-26-T8<br>30 days off for 14 days' leave | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 35m | 13 (6 new) | 218.6 | 42h 30m | 18 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 42m | 42 |
| **Next Step** NS-26-T6 | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 35m | 14 (6 new) | 218.6 | 42h 00m | 18 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 18m | 42 |
| **Open Return** OR-26-EXT<br>30 days off for 14 days' leave | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 0§ | 5<br>up to 6§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 13h 15m | 16 (8 new) | 218.6 | 43h 00m | 18 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 17m | 42 |
| **Second Edition** SE-26-F1 | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 6<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 20m | 15 (6 new) | 218.6 | 42h 00m | 18 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 01m | 42 |
| **Second Look** SL-26-G3 | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 0§ | 6<br>up to 6§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 20m | 14 (6 new) | 218.6 | 43h 40m | 15 of 21<br>blocks 4 (up to 6) | 1 | 1h 30m | 42 |
| **Set Fair** SF-26-T9<br>30 days off for 14 days' leave | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 0§ | 5<br>up to 6§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 35m | 12 (5 new) | 218.6 | 42h 30m | 19 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 06m | 42 |
| **Short Openers** SO-26-EXT<br>30 days off for 14 days' leave | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 0§ | 5<br>up to 6§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 13h 15m | 14 (6 new) | 218.6 | 42h 00m | 18 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 12m | 42 |
| **Short Run** SR-26-F1<br>★ shortlisted | **9 of 9** | **0**<br>up to 1§ | 5<br>up to 7§ | 7 in 26<br>about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most | 14h 20m | 15 (6 new) | 218.6 | 42h 30m | 18 of 21<br>blocks 5 (up to 7) | 0 | 1h 14m | 42 |

* Monday to Saturday, with a cover week counted as 4 days (Sundays are overtime and left out). † Each person, on average across the whole link, Sundays included; cover-week duties are not known yet and are left out. "Shift times" counts different start–finish times; "new" means nobody works that time today.

§ On the duties the rota fixes, the cover weeks left out for the proposal and today alike; "up to" is the worst place a cover week's four duties could fall, its Sunday worked as overtime — for the 55-hour week, as 8-hour duties. Avoidable fatigue warnings come from the ORR's good-practice list plus rail-industry checks, leaving out the two that come with the station and the link — the 06:20 open and a weekly rotation — and are reported, never pass or fail.

"Weeks on one shift time" means one shift time Monday to Friday, all earlies or all lates; beneath it, the longest block of weeks in a row on one kind, "up to" if the cover weeks beside it go the same way. The week-to-week change is the average move of the start time from one week to the next.

Full detail for each proposal is in its own eight-page sheet; the rules themselves are in links-26-rules.pdf.